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South Africa leads rest of Africa in AI adoption – Microsoft

Microsoft estimates 23.1% of working-age South Africans use generative AI – well ahead of the rest of the continent.

By Duncan McLeod – 18 May 2026



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South Africa is the highest-ranked country on the African continent for adoption of generative AI, according to new data from Microsoft – though the figures also show just how far the continent as a whole is trailing the rest of the world.

Microsoft's [Global AI Diffusion Q1 2026 report](#) (PDF), published by the company's [AI Economy Institute](#), estimates that 23.1% of South Africa's working-age population used a generative AI product in the first quarter of 2026, up from 21.1% in the second half of 2025. Microsoft's data places South Africa 46th of the 147 economies it measures – ahead of every other African country included in the dataset.

The gap to the rest of the continent is wide. The next-highest African economies are Namibia and Botswana, both at about 15%, followed by Egypt at 14.8%. Nigeria sits at 10.1% and Kenya at just 8.7%. Most of sub-Saharan Africa clusters near the bottom of the global table, with Uganda, Tanzania, Ethiopia and others below 8%.

Microsoft derived its AI diffusion measure from aggregated, anonymised telemetry from its own products, adjusted for differences in operating system and device market share, internet penetration and population. The company conceded that “no single metric is perfect” and described it as the strongest cross-country measure currently available. The figures are therefore Microsoft's modelled estimates rather than a precise headcount.

“ *Nigeria sits at 10.1%.
Most of sub-Saharan
Africa clusters near the
bottom of the global
table*

The report shows a widening gap between rich and poor economies. Microsoft estimates that AI usage in the Global North reached 27.5% in the first quarter of 2026, up 2.8 percentage points from the second half of 2025, while the Global South rose only 1.3 points to 15.4%. Adoption in the North, in other words, is growing more than twice as fast as in the South.

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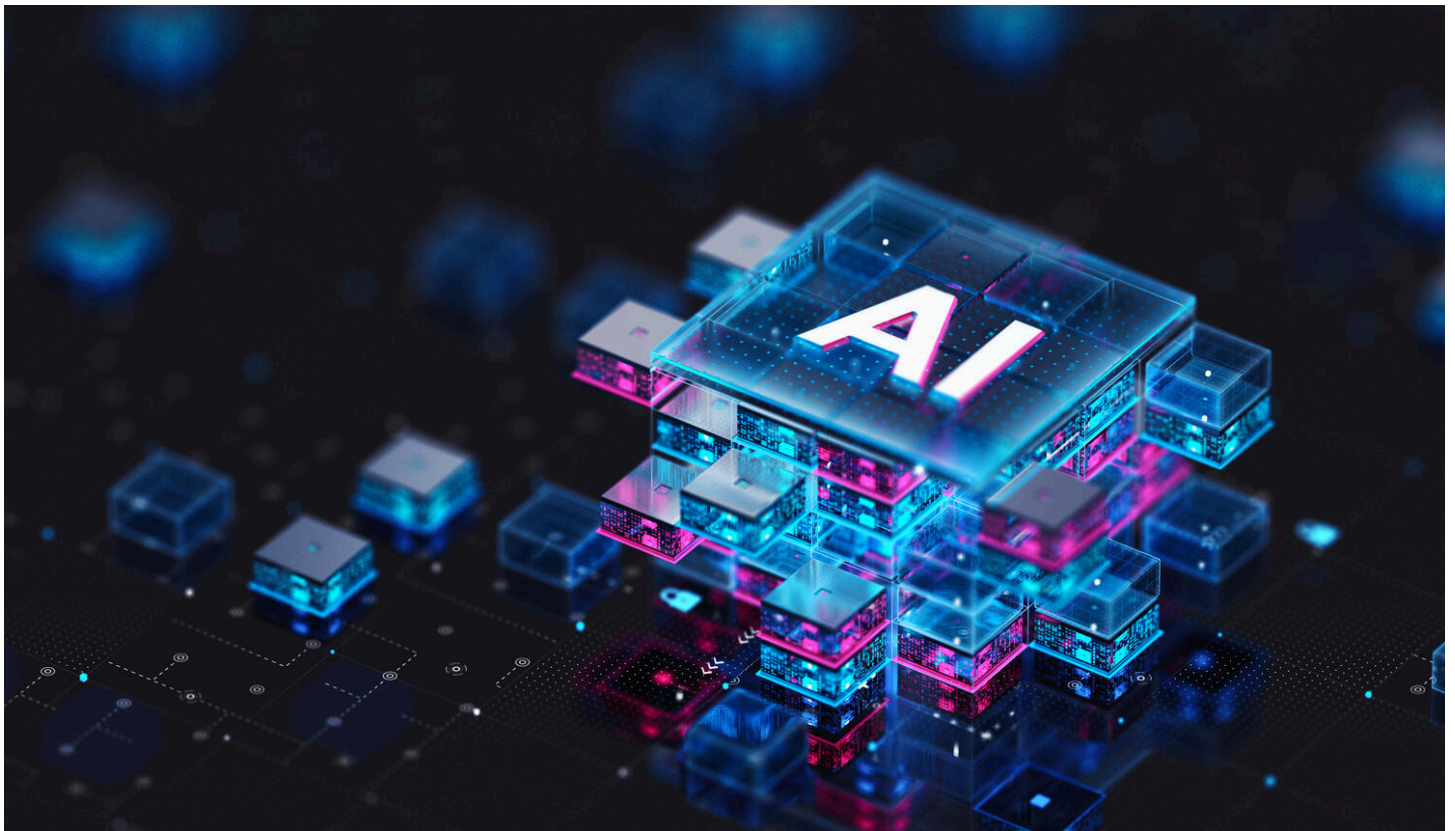
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At the top of the global ranking, the United Arab Emirates leads on 70.1%, followed by Singapore on 63.4%. Microsoft says Asia has become the primary engine of growth, with 12 of the 15 fastest-growing economies since June 2025 located in the region – a surge the report links partly to AI models becoming markedly better at handling Asian languages.

Read: US, China to coordinate on AI threats

The report's clearest evidence of AI's near-term economic impact is in software development. Microsoft says global "git pushes" – the mechanism by which developers upload code changes – rose 78% year on year, while the number of new code repositories grew 45%.

Activity tied to AI coding agents has grown sharply: merged pull requests associated with such agents rose from about 83 000 in May 2025 to 2.3 million in March 2026, though Microsoft says this captures only a fraction of AI-assisted development.



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2026 running about 4% ahead of a year earlier. It concludes that as AI lowers the cost of building software, organisations respond by building more of it. – © 2026 NewsCentral Media

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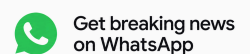
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DISQUS

The toll booth at the bottom of the sea

State-aligned Iranian media is floating a plan to charge the world's tech giants rent on subsea cables in the Strait of Hormuz.

By Nkosinathi Ndlovu — 18 May 2026

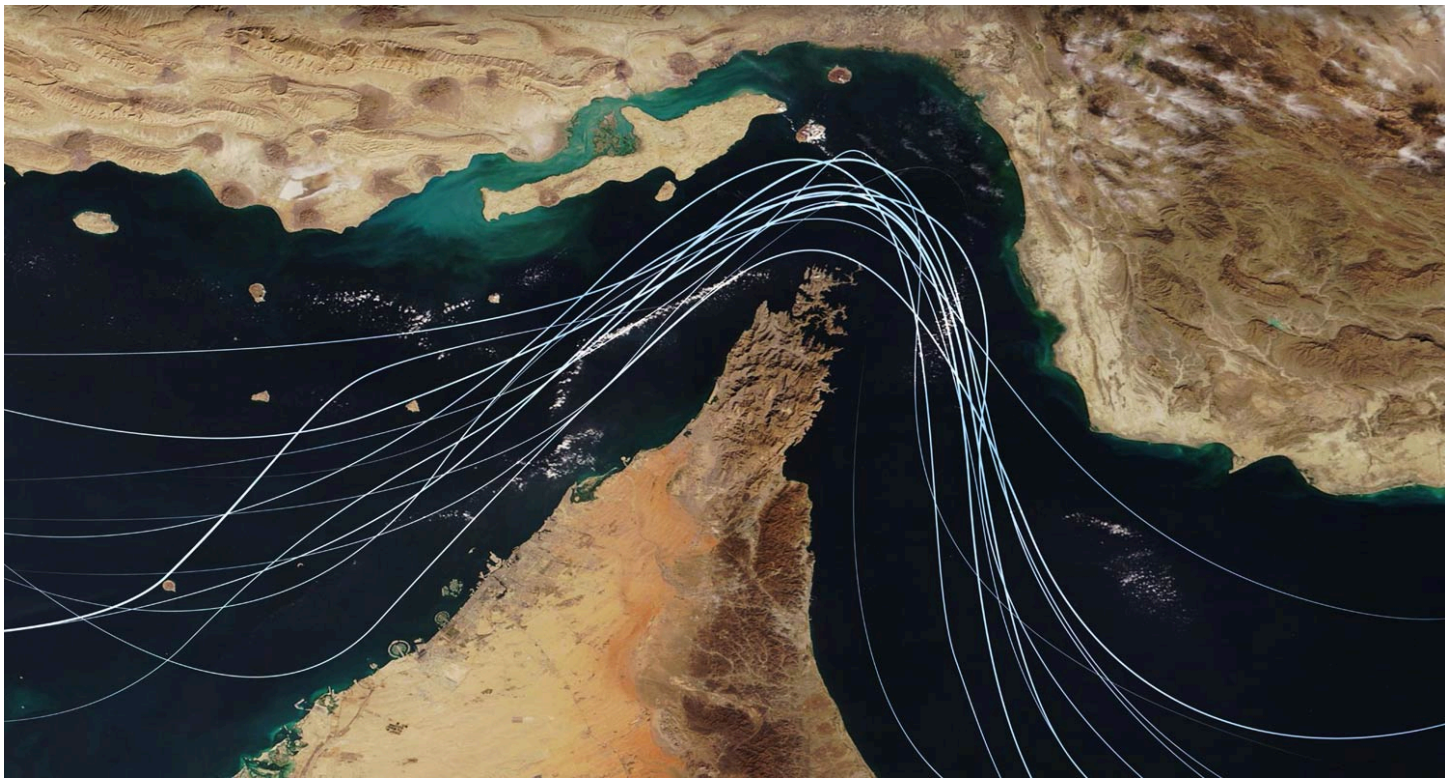


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The Strait of Hormuz at the entrance to the Persian Gulf

Iran is signalling that it wants to extract rent from the global data traffic flowing through the Strait of Hormuz, with state-aligned media floating a model under which the world's largest technology companies would pay licensing fees, submit to Iranian jurisdiction and hand maintenance of subsea cables to Iranian firms.

The proposals were published in recent days by Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps-linked outlets Tasnim and Fars and reported by **Rest of World**.

They outline initial licensing and annual renewal fees for foreign companies operating on the seabed, including likes of Meta, Amazon and Microsoft formally operating in the region. Iran wants control over the maintenance and repair of the cables.

Tasnim said the proposals were "for legitimate wealth creation", arguing the Islamic Republic would share the "foreign benefits of the communications infrastructure".



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May produced US\$2.2-trillion in investment pledges, anchored by Stargate UAE – a planned 5GW AI campus in Abu Dhabi by OpenAI, C42, Oracle, Nvidia and SoftBank that would be the largest AI campus in the world. Saudi Arabia's commitment to a Riyadh hub with Saudi

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work wrapped around those deals, including the shipping advanced chips out of Chinese hands, was threatened by Iranian missiles or Houthi drones.

becoming a hyperconnected country

occupies a critical bottleneck in global internet shortest, most direct route for undersea cables from the Red Sea and across its land to the Mediterranean. It has been accused of overcharging for capacity, with the high cost of international service providers.

the door to an explosion of comparable regimes with the risk being a resultant rise in the cost of

Iran's move has precedent in Egypt. Egypt occupies a critical bottleneck in global internet infrastructure

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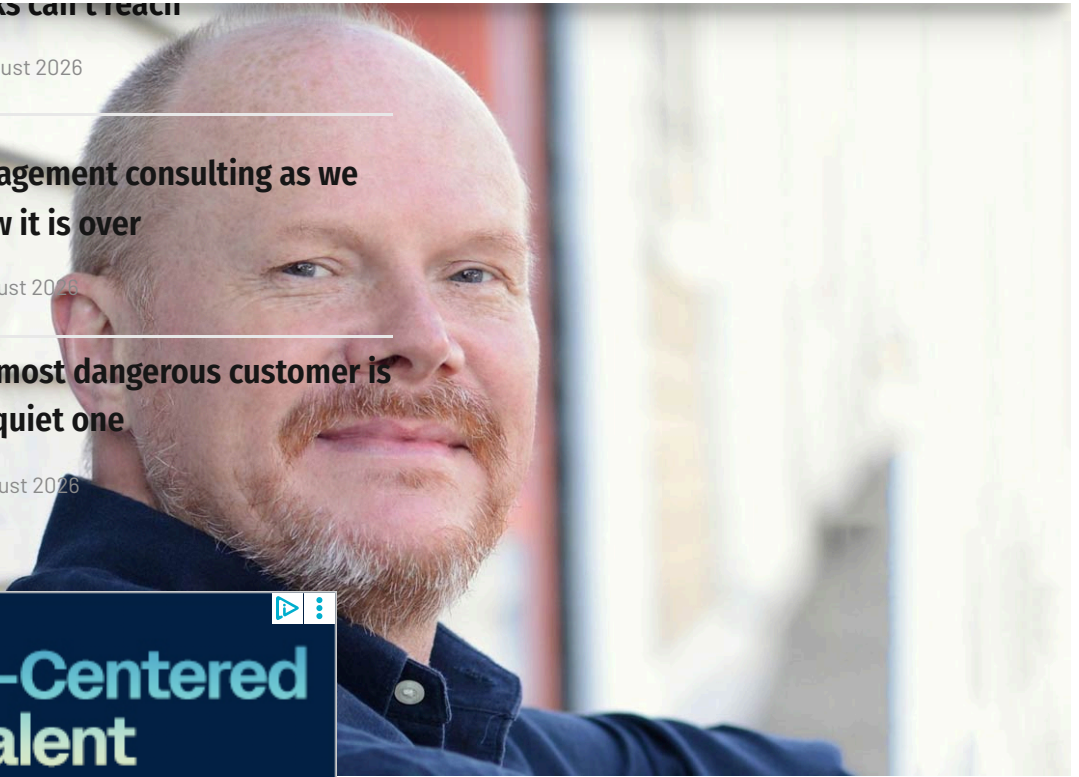
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sea cables off the coast of Côte d'Ivoire, they played a critical role in the restoration of Africa cable, nobody mentions the 400km necessary due to insecurity in the Red Sea.

absolutely critical to fibre infrastructure n, unlike undersea cables, is often very

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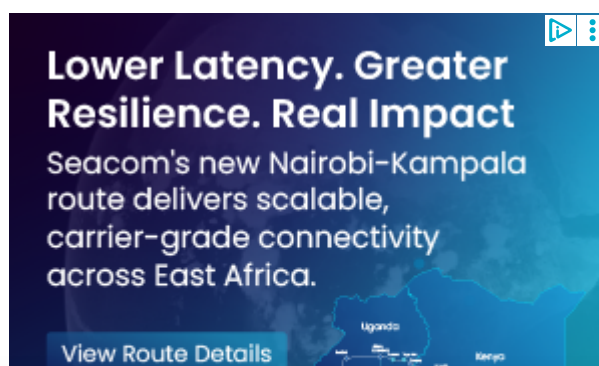
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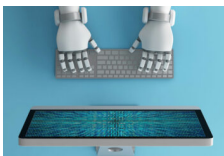
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